

CREATING SUSPENSE

Making the reader anxious to know what happens



1 What is it?

Creating Suspense

Creating suspense means making a reader **anxious to know what will happen** — stretching out the wait for an answer to keep them hooked.

a question + a delay = suspense

2 See it in action

A cliffhanger

Her hand closed around the door handle. She hesitated.

Delayed information

He opened the envelope slowly, painfully slowly, and began to read.

Foreshadowed danger

If only she'd known what waited for her at the end of the road.

Interrupted action

Just as the truth was about to come out, the phone rang.



Look here!

Find the **specific question** the writer is making you want answered — suspense always has a clear "what happens next?" driving it.

FUN FACT

Alfred Hitchcock famously explained suspense with a bomb under a table — if the audience knows the bomb is there and the characters don't, every ordinary line of dialogue becomes almost unbearable to sit through.

3 Why writers use it

Creating Suspense helps writers: keep a reader turning pages by delaying an answer they urgently want, build anticipation toward a reveal or twist, and control the pacing of information for maximum emotional payoff.

Suspense works best when the reader cares about the outcome — building suspense around something the reader is indifferent to has little effect, however slowly the reveal is stretched out.

4 Don't mix it up!

Suspense

- Anticipation about the **future**
- Built by delaying an answer
- A specific unknown outcome

Tension

- A feeling of **unease NOW**
- Built moment-to-moment
- Doesn't need a specific question



Watch out!

Suspense needs a genuine, specific question the reader wants answered — vaguely delaying the plot without a clear "what happens next?" just feels slow, not suspenseful.



You got this!

Notice **HOW** the answer is **delayed** — an interruption, a slow description, a chapter break — that delay technique is worth naming in your analysis.

5 Quick recap

Makes the reader
anxious to know more

Built by delaying an
answer

Keeps readers turning
the page



Good spot!

Try writing a paragraph where a character is about to reveal a secret, then interrupt it with something small and ordinary — notice how the delay itself creates suspense.